THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE **INNOVATORS**

For the Love of Storks

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Purnima created the Hargila Army, a women-led grassroots conservation movement that has transformed the Greater Adjutant Stork to a symbol of ecological pride

At an age when most children lose themselves in imaginary wonderlands, young Purnima Devi Barman found her muse in a bird that everyone feared. The Hargila, or the Greater Adjutant Stork, was regarded as an ill omen and despised for its ungainly appearance and scavenging habits. Years later, a phone call would turn that childhood fascination into a life's mission. A nesting tree had been cut down by villagers who believed the birds brought misfortune. When Barman rushed to rescue the fallen birds, she was met with hostility. Then a new mother to twin daughters, she picked up one of the injured chicks and felt an immediate connection, her thoughts going to her own children.

That moment transformed empathy into action. Barman went on to create the Hargila Army, a women-led grassroots conservation movement that today has over 2,000 female volunteers. And they do much more than protect nests. They have transformed the Greater Adjutant from a feared and mocked bird into a symbol of ecological pride and rural iden-



Photograph by **NILOTPAL BARUAH**

HER TAKE

"The Hargila carry on as nature's scavengers, even as many consider them a bad omen. Perhaps we humans can learn from them...take courage to keep doing what we believe in"